

The Widow Fen

31 August 2026

The party marched northeast into a drowning bog and nearly died in the first five minutes of it. What waited past that was a house in a tree, full of ledgers and jars and a sheaf of drawings of a face Morgash knows very well — and, at the bottom of a hollow trunk, two grieving sisters with a bargain. The sisters wanted a partner. The party did not take the terms. They came out with the second piece of the Heart, and they know now who sleeps under the tree in Greenrest's square.

The Land Drowns by Degrees

They rested at the ruins where Longshadow fell, took stock of what the last road had taught them, and moved out. Thomas called up a *Faithful Steed* — a fey thing, part horse and part hedgerow, leaves in its mane — and rode while the rest walked. The ground softened by the mile. The smell of muck came up. Then the trees quit and the world turned to water: black, root-tangled, and holding a mist that did not move with the wind.

Far out stood one enormous tree with cabins in its crown and lights burning in them. The water between was perfectly still — which was strange, because the reeds kept moving. Morgash read the fen better than anyone has read anything in weeks: frog-faced fey, bullywugs, a folk that normally keeps to itself. But these had a purplish-red glow behind the eyes that nothing natural puts there. Something had them on a string. He passed the word down the line, and Jetten set an arrow to the string of his bow.

The Sphere of Acid

It started well. Jetten set a *Hunter's Mark* and opened with *Dread Ambusher*, and the first warrior came off the reeds already bleeding. A second leapt thirty feet onto the islet and swung at Morgash twice, missed twice, and ate a *Riposte* for the privilege.

Then the robed one jumped into range and cast *Vitriolic Sphere*.

A ball of acid went up over the whole clustered party and burst. Every one of them tried to get clear. Not one of them did — Gren spent his *Heroic Inspiration* on a second try and the second try was no better than the first. The blast took all four at once, tore the *Hunter's Mark* and the *Bless* straight out of the air, and killed one of the caster's own warriors, which delighted it. It hopped up and down on its islet. Then the acid that was still clinging to them ate in a second time, and Thomas and Jetten both went down — Thomas's steed winking out of the world as he fell off it.

What got them out was everyone doing the right small thing at once. Jetten came back up and put a *Healing Word* into Thomas. Thomas spent his *Lay on Hands* on Gren, who was worse off than he was. Morgash refused to miss: twice he pulled a failing swing into a hit with a *Precision Attack*, and twice *Great Weapon Master* handed him a free follow-up for the kill; the Maul of Momentum put warrior after warrior flat on its back. He drank, he handed a potion to Jetten, and he kept standing when he had no business standing. Gren emptied a charge of his wand into the bog sage, and it was those missiles — not a blade — that finally put the caster down. Thomas took the last warrior with a *Divine Smite*.

Then Jetten did the cleverest thing anyone did all night. He cast *Rope Trick*, hung a rope in empty air, and took the whole party up into a cramped little pocket of nowhere with stars in the walls, and there they rested where nothing in the fen could reach them. Thomas worked the party over with his healer's kit while they did it, and every one of them came back down the rope in far better shape than they went up. Gren took the bog sage's staff off the body — a nasty thing that hits like a club and poisons like a snake.

The House in the Tree

Jetten went up alone first under *Pass without Trace*, put his head over the edge of a platform fifteen feet from a guard who never saw him, and came back down with a map of the place in his head. They argued about burning it — cut the bridges, drop the huts into the water — and then went up the one tree nobody was watching. Thomas laid an *Aid* over the three who would be taking hits. Morgash, in splint armour, was about as quiet as splint armour gets, and the croaking went up.

After the swamp, the house was almost restful. Two guards on the bridges went down fast. After that it was the furniture. A broom and a rug came off the floor of a bunk room; a sword and another broom stirred on a shelf; a second rug tried to smother whoever came through the door. None of it landed a blow worth the name. Jetten cut down the broom and the rug in a single turn. Gren, who had been missing everything he aimed at all evening, put a *Sorcerous Burst* through the flying sword so cleanly it snapped in half. Thomas cleaved a rug apart at his feet and pinned the sword flat with his shield. Morgash's maul finished two brooms in pieces.

The rooms were the real find. On the wash-lines: three sizes of shawl, pinned in threes, one set faded from years of weather and never taken down. In the larder: jars, labelled in a crabbed cipher — mourner's teeth, widow's tears, and one small jar packed in brine with a tiny flower drawn under the label, fondly, by someone. Thomas looked at that one a long time and said what everyone was thinking: *how is that not my wife's finger*. Gren checked the teeth and told him the truth, which was better than comfort — they were adult teeth, all of them. Nothing of his children was in that jar.

On the study desk lay a bill-of-lading book, and Thomas did not need to squint at it. It was the cipher he had copied a hundred times in Daggerford. He worked it end to end and it gave up everything: goods, prices, dates, and a drop-stone marked on the moor path the party had walked past that same afternoon. A ledger for the delivery of body parts. And the entries simply stop, a year and a half ago, right about when his family did. *This is exactly why I'm on this quest*.

Pinned above it, in plain Common in a tidy merchant's hand, was a single page that changed the shape of the night:

"The heart is broken in four. RED — the barrow. BLUE — ours, below. GREEN, BLACK — not yet found. The dryad sleeps in the great tree on Greenrest's square. The heart is hers. Whole, it beats four times. One beat brings back our sister. The red piece is moving. It is coming here. We need one beat only — they may keep the other three. Propose partnership. Do not fight."

The sisters knew the party was coming. They knew what the party was carrying. And "ours, below" meant there was a downstairs.

In another room, Morgash found a sheaf of loose charcoal pages — dozens of them, the same hard-jawed, sharp-eyed woman with a greatsword across her back, drawn over and over. Some careful as portraiture. Some slashed through hard enough to tear the paper. One burned at the corner. On the back of the top page, in two different hands: *HER. The one who took our sister. Do not let us forget her face.* He knew the face before he finished turning the page. Lae'zel. And he remembered her telling him, once, about a hag she had killed at a teahouse by a river outside Baldur's Gate.

A bundle in a bunk room, wrapped and rewrapped in oilcloth until the folds went soft, held a pressed flower gone colourless with age and a little hand-carved sign: *THE RIVERSIDE TEAHOUSE — SUNLIT WETLANDS — ALL WELCOME.* Someone in this house had kept it the way other people keep a wedding ring.

The Girl in the Cage

The trunk was hollow, and a stair wound down the inside of it, past the waterline, into the roots. At the bottom: candle-glow where there should have been pitch dark, the smell of tea and peat, a wall of jars floor to ceiling in that same cipher, cages, and a table set for company with three chairs and the tea still steaming.

And a little girl in one of the cages, with her finger over her lips.

Jetten picked the padlock with his dagger and she thanked him, over and over. Her name was Masie. They had taken her. And then the questions started coming the other way: how many of you are there? They said you were bringing a stone — do you have the stone? What are your names? Gren felt the wrongness of it before he could name it and said so out loud. But it was Morgash who broke it: the child came up and started *smelling* him, and then said, in a voice much older than eight, "*I smell Lae'zel on you.*" He swung at her. His hand went straight through.

The girl went out like a pinched candle, and two hags stepped out of the dark. Hazel and Mabel. They had been listening the whole time.

They were not, at first, hostile. They were *delighted* — at Morgash most of all: not only did she kill our sister, they said, she killed your heart too. She is a slayer after all. Then they made the offer the note had promised. Help us gather the Heart. One beat wakes our sister Ethel. The other three are yours. *Resurrect the world for all we care. We just need our sister.*

Thomas nearly took it, and for a reason nobody could argue with: they said they had the name. Not their own doing — they were only ever the buyers — but the people who had brought them the parts out of Daggerford were written in their ledgers, and they would give up that name for a bargain. The bargain they wanted was a binding one: if either side fails, you die. Thomas offered a paladin's oath instead, and Hazel told him what she thought a vengeance paladin's oath was worth to her. Jetten would not deal at any price. Gren pushed for the location of the dryad and got it — she broke her own heart, she is older than the hags, and she is trapped beneath the great tree in Greenrest's square by her own grief — and then the answers stopped.

Hazel ran out of patience first. *These aren't going to bargain with us. Let's kill them, sister, and be done with this.*

Two Rounds

It was over almost before it started.

Hazel opened with a *Suggestion* at Gren — you can't remember any of your spells — and Gren shrugged it off without breaking stride. She followed with a *Hex*. Armour and a broom and a sword began rumbling in out of the dark.

Gren answered with everything at once. *Innate Sorcery*, then a *Fireball* bent around every one of his allies by *Careful Spell* — the fire went through the room and touched nothing but the enemy. The broom, the sword and the armour all failed to get clear; a last flick of *Spellfire Burst* finished the armour where it stood. And he looked at Hazel through the smoke and told her he had not forgotten a single one of his spells.

Morgash went at Mabel and found the perfect seam of her, an *Action Surge* buying him swings he had no right to, the maul's *Topple* putting her on the floor twice over. She *Misty Stepped* out of his reach with almost nothing left, and he called after her that there was nowhere she could go. Thomas hammered Hazel with *First Light* and broke her *Hex* apart with a *Divine Smite*. And Jetten, at range, put an arrow through Mabel and finished her.

Hazel was left alone in her own kitchen. She was offered her life — Gren tried to hold her still to take her alive, and she threw it off; Thomas kept trying to talk her into a deal she would hate. She would not have it. *You just killed my sister. Do you think I'm going to make any deal with you? I'd rather die.* Morgash's maul put her prone, and he stood over her and asked whether she wanted to be knocked out instead of killed. She looked up at him, spat, and told him to get on with it.

He got on with it. As she went down she reached for something at her throat, and it did not save her, and a blue stone rolled out of her open hand.

The Second Piece

The Tideheart. A quarter of a heart turned to crystal: deep water blue, clear and cold, like light coming a long way up through black water. Two cupped hands would hold it. The chambering and the sheared-off vessels are still inside the stone like flaws in a gem. It is warmer than the air around it, which is the wrong thing for something pulled out of a fen, and it beats — slowly, faintly. It does not chip and it does not scratch. It has already been broken.

Whoever took it up saw exactly what the Graveheart showed: the green woman crowned with leaves, weeping, closing her hands over her own chest — and her heart bursting, the pieces scattering and hardening as they flew, the mist driven back in a great ring from a bare green valley beside a lake.

Thomas went straight to the jar-wall, and it was all there in the same hand as the ledger upstairs: sources, prices, dates, years of them. Every Daggerford shipment accounted for. These two were the buyers — that much is now certain. But nowhere on that wall, in all those years of careful accounting, is the name of the man who sent the parts. Hazel died with it.

The rest of the room told its own story. A crocodile skeleton with a skull taller than a man, hung with pots and ladles — a kitchen rack far longer than it was ever a threat. Cages holding a kettle, a fiddle, a set of bellows, all gone still and ordinary. And one cage with packed straw in it, and a child's skeleton, and the name *Masie* scratched into the breastbone. Whoever she was, she died a long time ago. The thing in the cage had been wearing her.

They stripped the tea table of everything worth carrying and went out through a corridor screened with marsh plants, into daylight. They made the edge of Greenrest just before the sun went down. A scout on the road saw them coming, and waved, and welcomed them in.

Spoils & Progress

- **The Tideheart** — the blue shard, the second of four. In the party stash, unclaimed and unattuned. All four are carrying a full set of attunements, so somebody has to give something up.
- **The Widows' Ledger** — the Daggerford cipher, fully read: the goods, the prices, the drop-stone on the moor path, and the date the deliveries stopped.
- **The Sisters' Notes** — four pieces, the colours, and the dryad under the tree in Greenrest.
- **Sheaf of Charcoal Sketches** and the **Riverside Teahouse Keepsake**.
- Three grief-jars — mourner's teeth, widow's tears, and a mother's little finger — and an annotated copy of *Volo's Guide to Monsters* that nobody has read properly yet.
- **The Bog Staff**, off the bog sage — a club that carries a heavy dose of poison with every hit. Currently in Gren's hands.
- Roughly **three thousand gold** in sellables out of the hags' household: three ornate teacups, two oil paintings, a gilt-framed portrait of a merchant nobody recognises, a bolt of silk, a silver tea service, a rolled tapestry, whalebone combs, wired dragon bones, and five bags of very good tea.

Quotable Quotes

"I smell Lae'zel on you."

— the little girl in the cage, a moment before Morgash's hand went through her.

"Resurrect the world for all we care. We just need our sister."

— the offer, which was more generous than anyone expected.

"The oath of a vengeance paladin means nothing to me."

— Hazel, declining Thomas's word as collateral.

"I did not forget any of my spells. Ask the squirrels about my reputation."

— Gren, standing in the smoke of his own fireball.

"No matter where you go, I'm going to find you."

— Morgash, to a hag who had just teleported out of his reach. He was right.

"Do it. I have nothing to live for."

— Hazel, refusing to be taken alive.

"These are adult teeth. I don't think you have anything to worry about."

— Gren to Thomas, over an open jar, and it was the kindest thing said all night.

"Well, we're almost dead in this round. We might not make it to the hags."

— Jetten, in the acid, correctly.

Deeds of the Day

- **The Rope to Nowhere** — Jetten, for hanging a door in thin air and putting the whole party somewhere the fen could not follow, at the exact moment it was needed.
- **Last One Standing** — Morgash, who took the worst of the acid, never went down, killed both sisters' worth of trouble, and finished the night by being asked for mercy and asking first whether she wanted it.
- **Kindest Cut** — Gren, who looked into the jar Thomas could not look into, and told him the truth instead of a comfort.
- **The Cipher Keeper** — Thomas, who read a dead ring's books at a glance and found, in a swamp four days from home, the exact records he has been chasing since Daggerford.
- **Best Use of a Broom** — awarded to nobody; the broom lost.

Next time: The party walks into Greenrest at dusk with two pieces of the Heart and a name they did not get. Somewhere under the old grey tree in the square, something has been asleep for a very long time — and they are the first people in this valley to know it is there.

Recorded at the table — transcribed & chronicled by the party scribe.